

Expense Approval Workflow

Process Documentation | Finance Operations

Document Owner: Finance Department

Applies To: U.S. entities and UAE entities (UAE equivalents are shown in brackets)

Effective Date: August 2026

Version: 1.1 (see Revision History)

Review Cycle: Annually, or when the expense policy changes

Portfolio sample. The organization, systems, limits, and timelines in this document are illustrative.

1. Overview

This workflow explains how employees submit business expense claims, how claims are reviewed and approved, and how reimbursement is processed, in line with the company expense policy. It also explains what to do when a receipt is missing, a claim is large, or a claim is returned.

2. Definitions

Term	Meaning
Expense claim	A request, submitted in the expense system, to be reimbursed for business costs the employee paid personally.
Pre-approval	Written approval obtained before an expense is incurred. It is required for international travel and for any single expense above the claim limit.
Itemized receipt	A receipt that lists the vendor, date, each item purchased, tax, total, and payment method. A card payment slip alone is not itemized.
Business purpose	A short statement of why the expense was needed for work, for example "Client lunch with ABC Co. to review renewal terms."
Expense system	The online tool used to submit and approve claims, for example Concur (supports U.S. and UAE entities) or Expensify (U.S. teams).

3. Roles and Responsibilities

Role	Responsibilities	Target time
Employee	Submits the claim with itemized receipts, a business purpose, and any pre-approval.	Within 5 business days of the expense date or trip return
Line Manager	Reviews the claim for accuracy and business relevance. Approves it or returns it with comments.	2 business days
Finance Team	Verifies receipts, checks policy compliance, flags discrepancies, and schedules reimbursement.	3 business days
Controller or Finance Manager	Approves claims over USD 1,000. [UAE: AED 3,700, Finance Director approval.]	2 business days

4. Process Steps

Step	Owner	Action	Target time
1	Employee	Submit the claim in the expense system with itemized receipts, a business purpose, and any pre-approval.	Within 5 business days
2	Line Manager	Review the claim for accuracy and business relevance. Approve it, or return it with comments.	2 business days
3	Finance Team	Verify receipts and policy compliance. Flag any discrepancies to the employee.	3 business days
4	Controller or Finance Manager	Only for claims over USD 1,000 [UAE: AED 3,700]: review and approve.	2 business days
5	Finance Team	Schedule reimbursement on the next bi-weekly payroll or accounts payable (AP) run.	Next scheduled run

Expense Approval Workflow

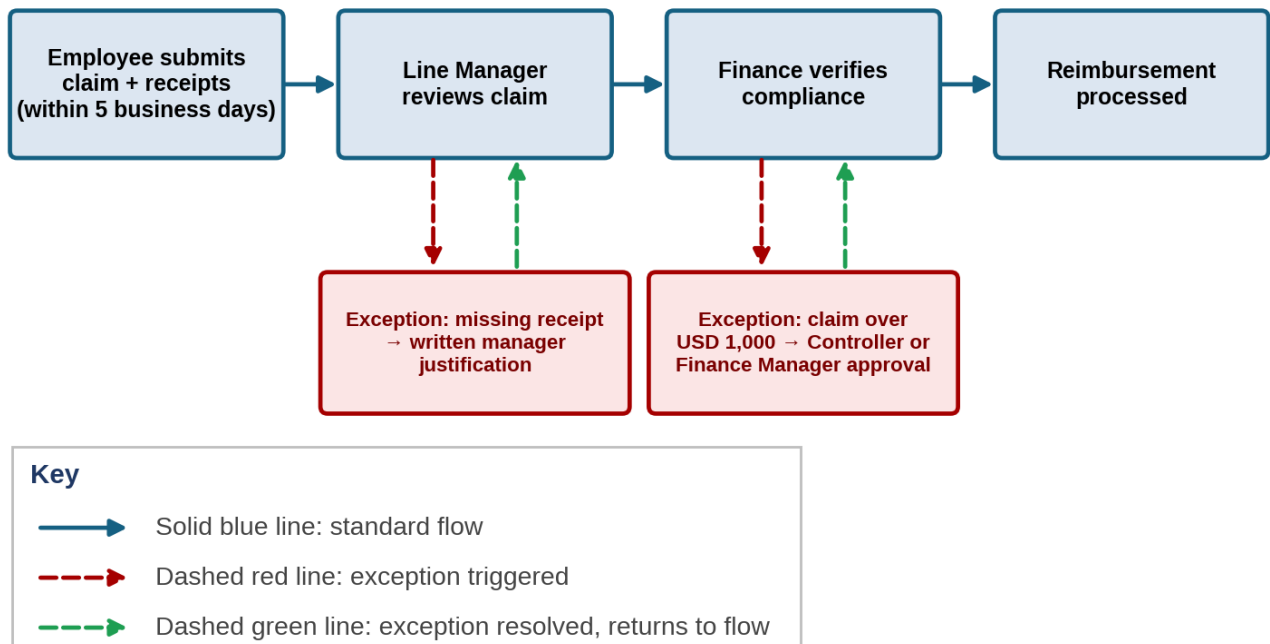


Figure 1. Expense approval workflow, including exception paths.

5. Exceptions and Special Cases

Situation	What to do
Missing receipt	Submit the claim with a written justification from the Line Manager and a short statement from the employee describing the purchase. Finance may still decline the item.

Situation	What to do
Claim over USD 1,000 [UAE: AED 3,700]	The claim also needs approval from the Controller or Finance Manager [UAE: Finance Director] after the Line Manager approves it.
Foreign currency expense	Enter the amount in the original currency. The system converts it using the rate on the transaction date. Attach the card or bank statement if the receipt does not show the rate.
Company card purchase	Submit the receipt in the expense system so the card statement can be reconciled. No reimbursement is paid.
Receipt mixes business and personal items	Claim only the business portion and note the split in the business purpose.
Submitted after the 5-day deadline	The Line Manager adds a short explanation. Late claims are still accepted but may be delayed or need additional verification.
Claim returned or rejected	The employee receives the reason, corrects the claim, and resubmits it within 5 business days of the return.

6. What Can and Cannot Be Reimbursed

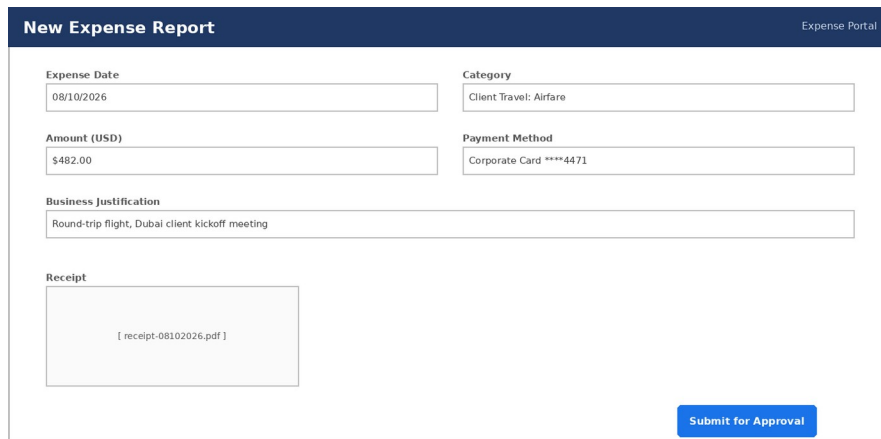
Category	Usually reimbursable	Not reimbursable
Travel	Economy airfare or rail, ground transport for business, hotel at the approved rate	Upgrades, personal side trips, fines and penalties
Meals	Business meals within the per-person limit, with attendee names and business purpose	Meals with no business purpose or attendee list
Other business costs	Pre-approved equipment, software, and supplies; client-facing costs with a business purpose	Items bought without pre-approval where it was required
Personal items	None	Personal entertainment, minibar charges, personal purchases

The per-person meal limit and approved hotel rates are set in the Travel & Expense Policy on the company intranet.

7. Completing the Claim

A complete claim is approved faster. Before you submit, check the following:

- Every expense line has its own itemized receipt attached.
- Each line has a business purpose written in plain words, not just a category.
- The pre-approval is attached, if one was required.
- The amounts and dates in the form match the receipts.



The image shows a web form titled "New Expense Report" with a dark blue header. The form is divided into several sections: "Expense Date" with a date picker set to 08/10/2026; "Category" with a dropdown menu showing "Client Travel: Airfare"; "Amount (USD)" with a text input set to \$482.00; "Payment Method" with a dropdown menu showing "Corporate Card ****4471"; "Business Justification" with a text area containing "Round-trip flight, Dubai client kickoff meeting"; and "Receipt" with a placeholder image labeled "[receipt-08102026.pdf]". A blue "Submit for Approval" button is located at the bottom right of the form.

Figure 2. Expense submission screen (fictional sample).

What an itemized receipt shows

A complete receipt shows the vendor name, date, each item with its price, tax, the total, and the payment method.



The image shows a sample itemized receipt from "SkyLine Airways". The receipt is titled "SkyLine Airways" and "Passenger Receipt | Sample Data". It lists the following information: Passenger: A. Martinez; Confirmation #: SLY-482910; Route: JFK → DXB → JFK; Travel Date: 09/02/2026 - 09/06/2026; Fare: \$412.00; Taxes & Fees: \$70.00; Total Charged: \$482.00; Payment Method: Corporate Card ****4471.

Figure 3. Itemized receipt (fabricated sample for illustration only).

8. Common Reasons Claims Are Returned

Reason	How to avoid it
The receipt is a card slip, not itemized.	Ask the vendor for an itemized receipt at the time of purchase.
The business purpose is missing or vague.	Write who, what, and why, for example "Taxi to client site, ABC Co. meeting."
The expense was over the limit with no pre-approval.	Check the limit in the policy and request approval before spending.
The same expense was submitted twice.	Check the claim history, including company card entries, before submitting.
The claim was submitted late.	Submit within 5 business days, or ask your Line Manager to add an explanation.

9. Timeline

Claim type	Review and approval	Reimbursement
Standard claim	Up to 5 business days (Line Manager 2, Finance 3)	Next scheduled bi-weekly payroll or AP run
Claim over USD 1,000 [UAE: AED 3,700]	Up to 7 business days (adds 2 days for Controller or Finance Manager)	Next scheduled bi-weekly payroll or AP run

Reimbursement is typically received within 1 to 2 weeks of submission, assuming complete documentation and no exceptions.

10. Related Documents

- [Internal Travel Request FAQ](#): for travel approval before the trip.
- [Travel Cost Estimate Calculator](#): for estimating trip costs before requesting approval.
- Travel & Expense Policy: company intranet.

11. Revision History

Version	Date	Author	Summary of Changes
1.0	August 14, 2026	Kathleen (Katie) Taylor	Initial release
1.1	October 7, 2026	Kathleen (Katie) Taylor	Added definitions, target times, submission deadline, special cases, reimbursable items table, claim checklist, and common return reasons; corrected the diagram to show the Controller approval path